20 TRAINING CHILDREN AGES 1-10

Let's discuss some practical financial ideas for young children, ages 1 through 10. Normally, during the first 10 years, the basic attitudes of your children are being formed. You're not going to change their basic personalities no matter what you do. But you can mold their character by reinforcing their strong points and correcting their flaws. The way they manage money is merely a measure of their strengths and weaknesses.

For young children, you need to assign some nonpaying jobs, such as cleaning their rooms, doing the dishes, and picking up their toys. As Proverbs 15:20 says, "A wise son makes a father glad, but a foolish man despises his mother." All children need some basic responsibilities for which they don't get paid. My children used to object because I started implementing this philosophy in our family, admittedly a bit late. They usually felt like they should get paid for everything they did. The point I tried to get across was, we're all part of a society and each of us has things we *have* to do. I would usually point out that if I didn't get paid for changing their diapers when they were young, they don't get paid for taking out the garbage now.

You should also provide some paying jobs for your children. These might include lawn care, cleaning the garage, washing the car, and so on. There are a variety of things for which you should pay your children, and you should pay them equitably, according to what you are able to afford.

When we lived in Tucker, Georgia (just outside Atlanta), we owned a house on a steep hill; in fact, if you stepped onto my front yard without baseball cleats on, you could end up in my backyard! So obviously, it was a tough lawn to mow. My oldest son was very compliant; whatever I asked him to do, he did it. When I said, "Please mow the lawn," he mowed it and whatever I paid him was OK, within reason.

My second son questioned everything. (If you ever have a child who says, "Why?" then you'll understand.) He had 99